



Watercolor Still Life

Grade 6
Watercolor



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Last Revised: December 2024

WATERCOLOR STILL LIFE

Length: 75 minutes

Number of docents: 2

Purpose:

- To have students further their knowledge of color relationship and pattern.
- To create a painting using varying tints, shades and intensities.
- To create a still life in the style of Henri Matisse.

Visual Arts Standards:

- Formulate an artistic investigation of personally relevant content for creating art. (6.VA:Cr1.2)
- Demonstrate openness in trying new ideas, materials, methods, and approaches in making works of art and design. (6.VA:Cr2.1)
- Reflect on whether personal artwork conveys the intended meaning and revise accordingly. (6.VA:Cr3)

Unit Contains: Supply box and portfolio

Materials docent will bring per student:

- a few sheets of 11"x 15" sheets of watercolor paper (for absent student)
- test strips
- #10 brushes
- Variety of fruits/vegetables
- Color wheel
- Extra paints in 6 colors (red, yellow, blue, orange, purple, brown)
- Patterned tablecloth
- Poster with techniques illustrated
- Droppers for docents/parents

Materials teacher will provide per student:

- Completed still life drawing
- Watercolors
- Container of water
- Paper towels

Featured works:

<i>Purple Robe and Anemones</i> , 1937	Henri Matisse
<i>Interior with Dog</i> , 1934	Henri Matisse
<i>Ginger Jar</i> , c. 1895	Paul Cezanne
<i>Three Green Pears</i> , 2013	Sharon Freeman
<i>Fresh Vegetables</i> , 2009	Sue Zimmermann

SET-UP

Display a variety of fruits, vegetables and the blue pitcher on the patterned tablecloth in the front of the class. No need to recreate the still life they drew in the previous lesson but it is important that all the fruits and vegetables are displayed so students can see the colors and shading.

Give each student their still life drawing, watercolor set, water, paper towel, brush.
Use the docent sample from the Drawing lesson to demonstrate the watercolor techniques.

INTRODUCTION (5 minutes)



Purple Robe and Anemones
Henri Matisse
Oil on canvas
33" x 28"



Interior with Dog, 1934.
Henri Matisse
Oil on canvas
61" x 66"



Ginger Jar
Paul Cezanne
Oil on canvas
29" x 24"



Three Green Pears
Sharon Freeman
Watercolor on paper



Fresh Vegetables
Sue Zimmermann
Watercolor on paper

Suggested Dialog: Display all of the prints, discuss the art elements and Matisse's style of painting focusing on color and pattern in a short lecture style:

- Do you notice the contrasting colors near each other?
- Can you see the warm colors here, the cool colors there?
- Notice which colors stand out.
- Look at all of the patterns used in these prints. Point out how the patterns draw the eye around the painting.
- Point out repeated patterns and colors. Refer to the color wheel too.

- Contrast the Cezanne print to the Matisse prints.
- If students don't notice, point out Cezanne's use of color and shading on the fruits.

Tell the class that today they will be using paint to add colors and patterns to their drawing.

PAINTING

- **Prime the paints.** Note: students need frequent reminders during this lesson to keep their paints primed with enough water for painting.
- Look at the colors of the fruits/vegetables. Each piece of fruit or vegetable has **more than a single solid color**. The colors in our paint box are not quite right, so we need to create new ones—edible colors that look good enough to eat. No poison green straight from the paint box!
 - **Two colors on the brush.** Review this list with the class based on the still life in the classroom and choose one combo to demonstrate on one object in the still life drawing:
 - Yellow tipped in red: oranges
 - Orange tipped in blue: pears
 - Red tipped in blue: apples
 - Blue tipped in red: eggplants, cabbage
 - Yellow tipped in blue: mango, peppers
 - Students paint one object in their drawing (but not the largest object) using two colors on the brush after demo.
 - **Wet into Wet:** Show how to add a blush of color by painting a new color into a wet color: (choose one to demo on another object in the still life drawing)
 - Red apple with blue shading
 - Yellow pear with red or green blush
 - Yellow apple with red streaks
 - Green leaves with blue or purple shadows
 - Students paint one object in their drawing (but not the largest object) using wet into wet technique after docent demo.
- **Create the effect of roundness by shading and highlights.** Point out highlights and shading in the still life. Review all techniques, but demo just one on the largest object:
 - Paint from a dark color to a lighter color (gradation) by removing paint from your brush and adding water.
 - Remove paint by using a dry brush or paper towel.
 - Leave a white area in an object.
 - Students paint the pitcher in their drawing using shading and highlights.
- **Review brush techniques to create texture or to paint squiggly objects.** Think about the texture of each piece of fruit or vegetable. Is it smooth and shiny with white spots or dull and rough with lots of bumps?

- **Stipple stroke** can be used for rough texture. Stipple can be done on top of dry paint or wet in wet for patterns.
- **Squiggle stroke** for curvy things like cabbage.
- These techniques can be used for the patterns on the tablecloth and background walls.
- Demo these techniques on one of the background areas or tablecloth.
- Students use stipple or squiggle on one of their background areas or tablecloth.

B. Students finish painting their still life.

Give students a few suggestions before starting and throughout painting time.

- **Think through your color scheme before you start.**
- **Use complementary colors adjacent to each other.** Contrast the still life with the background and tablecloth patterns.
- **Repeat the colors of some objects** in the foreground or background. This gives unity to the painting.
- **Avoid the wet paint of adjacent objects** running together by skipping around your composition when painting.
- Remember that **watercolors are lighter when dry** so use plenty of pigment.
- Remind students to add water and prime their paints again when they get dry. (Having wet paints helps them cover their painting efficiently.)

Parent Instructions for Watercolor Still Life

Thank you for volunteering today!

Please help by:

Setting up lesson supplies

- Clear desks/tables
- Pass out students still life drawings (get students to help), paper towel, brush, watercolor paints, and ½ filled water container
- Dirty paint palettes can be cleaned with a wet brush and wiping with a wet paper towel.



During the lesson

- Listen carefully to the docent instructions to the students
- Assist individual students by walking around the room
- Refresh water as needed
- Use droppers to re-prime paints as needed
- Encourage students to use paint techniques shown
- Remind students to continue to prime paints as they become dry

Additional tips

- Please don't work on students' art — demonstrate on scrap materials
- Ask Art Docents if a student needs extra help
- Have fun!

Helping clean-up

- Clean brushes thoroughly by washing out excess paint in water
- Wipe out lid of paint palettes, clean with a wet brush if needed
- Leave paint lids open to dry
- Paper towels can be recycled
- Wipe down tables if needed

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Revision History

Revision Date	Docent Name	Comments
1983	Nancy Marston, Dana James and Karen Drucker	Developed
1999	Committee lead by Bonnie Sorenson	Revision
2005	Committee lead by Clara Krispie	Option of artificial or fresh fruits and veggies
November 2011	Committee lead by Elena Shea	Simplify still life arrangement, take out inking step
February 2013	Curriculum Committee	Added suggestions for docents to give feedback to children
September 2014	Curriculum Committee	Lesson broken into 2 part lesson – drawing/inking and painting
May 2015	Elena Shea	Students only paint patterns, not drawn in advance. Simplified and shortened introduction with fewer prints.
May 2019	Kimberly Dickerson	New VAPA Standards added
October 2021	Anke Delingat	Added Fresh Vegetables watercolor print by Sue Zimmerman
March 2022	Anke Delingat	Added Three Green Pears watercolor print by Sharon Freeman
May 2024	Curriculum Committee	Parent Volunteer Instructions added
December 2024	Curriculum Committee	Lesson extended to 75 mins